

Words For The Young Girls And Boys

[B1]

La storia di questi due termini ci ricorda che anche le parole più semplici, quelle che usiamo nella vita di tutti i giorni, possono avere origini curiose e insospettabilmente complesse.



Some of the most familiar words in English have changed their meanings over time as the English language and society have evolved. The [noun](#) ‘girl’ is perhaps one of the most fascinating examples. The word appeared in the 13th century and was gender-neutral: it did not indicate biological sex, [but rather](#) age and could refer both to boys and to girls. In other words, ‘girl’ simply meant ‘child’, ‘youngster’; a ‘young person’, who could be male or female.

MORAL MEANING

At the time, the most common term for referring specifically to girls was ‘[maid](#)’ (or ‘[maiden](#)’), a word that indicated a young woman, especially if unmarried or a virgin (the moral meaning was very important back then.) Later, ‘[maid](#)’ [narrowed](#) in meaning and came to mean ‘female servant’, while ‘[maiden](#)’ survived mainly with an archaic or literary flavour. Over time, ‘girl’ replaced ‘[maiden](#)’ with the meaning of ‘female child’ or ‘young woman’.

FROM NEUTRAL TO FEMININE

Between the late 13th and 14th centuries, the word ‘girle’, ‘gurle’ or ‘gyrle’ became established. These are simply [spelling variants](#) of Middle English, mainly found in the dialects of central and northern England. Such variation is normal: spelling was not standardised and writers often wrote words by ear. In medieval texts expressions such as a “girle of ten yere” (a young person of ten years) are common. However, ‘girle’ on its own was not enough to specify sex. This is why medieval texts also contain expressions like ‘knave-girle’ meaning ‘boy’ and ‘mayde-girle’ meaning ‘girl’. Language

That's Nice! The Journey Of A Word Dal latino all'inglese moderno, la parola ‘nice’ ne ha fatta di strada! Ed è strano pensare che questo aggettivo, oggi usato per indicare qualcosa di piacevole, sia nato come un insulto. Daniel Francis , Graziella Del Ciuco

GENDER-SPECIFIC

Between the late Middle Ages (the 14th and 15th centuries) and the early modern period, something decisive happened: a gender specialisation took place. ‘Boy’ became fixed for males, ‘[maid](#)’ became increasingly tied to ideas of virginity and moral status, while ‘girle’ was more and more often used to refer to young females. This process [gave rise to](#) the modern word ‘girl’.

FROM SERVANT TO LITTLE BOY

The word 'boy' also appears in English in the 13th century, in forms such as 'boi', 'boie' or 'boye'. At the time, the term was often used to mean '[rascal](#), [mischievous](#) child, low-class youth'. Its origin is not completely clear, which is unusual for such a common word and it does not seem to be clearly related to Latin or to the main classical Germanic [roots](#). In medieval texts, 'boy' does not simply mean 'child': it often refers to a servant, helper, or apprentice, that is, a young male defined primarily by his inferior social position rather than by his role as a son within the family. Over time, 'boy' gradually lost its social meaning and became restricted to age: from 'subordinate young person' it came to mean simply 'male child'.

HOW DO YOU SAY...?

Brava!/Bravo! Attagirl!/Attaboy!

Glossary

- **rascal** = furfante, canaglia
- **roots** = radici
- **noun** = sostantivo
- **maid** = ragazza
- **narrowed** = restringere
- **spelling variants** = varianti ortografiche
- **mischievous** = dispettoso, birichino
- **but rather** = bensì
- **maiden** = donzella
- **gave rise to** = dare origine a